# Dubai Travel Guide

*Skyscrapers, desert adventures and a global airline hub - United Arab Emirates*

## Dubai: Overview and History

Dubai is one of the seven emirates of the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and lies on the Persian Gulf. For centuries it was a small fishing and pearl-diving village built around Dubai Creek, a natural saltwater inlet.

Oil was discovered in Dubai in 1966, and in 1971 Dubai joined other emirates to form the United Arab Emirates. Rulers of the Al Maktoum family used oil money to build ports, airports and tourism, turning Dubai into a global business and travel hub.

Today Dubai is famous for record-breaking architecture, luxury shopping and desert experiences. The city hosted the world's fair Expo 2020, which took place from 2021 to 2022. Its home airline, Emirates, connects Dubai with cities on every inhabited continent, including London, Sydney, Singapore, New York and Tokyo.

Arabic is the official language, but English is widely spoken. The weekend in Dubai is Saturday and Sunday, and Friday is a half working day.

# Dubai: Top Attractions

The Burj Khalifa is the tallest building in the world at 828 metres. It opened in 2010 and its observation decks, called At the Top, are on levels 124, 125 and 148. At its foot, the Dubai Fountain puts on a free show of water, music and lights every evening.

The Dubai Mall is one of the largest shopping centres in the world, with an aquarium, an ice rink and hundreds of shops. The sail-shaped Burj Al Arab hotel and the palm-shaped artificial island of Palm Jumeirah are iconic sights along the coast.

The Museum of the Future, opened in 2022, is a striking ring-shaped building covered in Arabic calligraphy. The Dubai Frame is a giant golden picture frame with views of old and new Dubai.

For history, visit the Al Fahidi Historical Neighbourhood, with its wind-tower houses, and take a traditional wooden abra boat across Dubai Creek to the Gold Souk and the Spice Souk in Deira. A desert safari with dune driving and dinner at a desert camp is a favourite evening activity.

# Dubai: Neighborhoods and Food

Downtown Dubai is home to the Burj Khalifa and Dubai Mall. Dubai Marina is a forest of residential towers around a canal, with a waterfront walk and many restaurants, next to the beach at JBR. Deira and Bur Dubai, on either side of the creek, are the old trading districts with busy souks.

Jumeirah is a residential beach area with relaxed cafes, and Alserkal Avenue in Al Quoz is the centre of the contemporary art scene.

Emirati food reflects the Gulf's trading history. Al machboos is spiced rice with meat or fish, and luqaimat are sweet fried dumplings with date syrup. Arabic coffee, called gahwa, is flavoured with cardamom and served with dates as a sign of hospitality.

Dubai's huge expatriate population means you can find food from almost every country, from shawarma and Indian biryani to world-class fine dining. During the holy month of Ramadan, visitors should avoid eating or drinking in public during daylight hours.

# Dubai: Getting Around and Practical Tips

The Dubai Metro has two driverless lines, the Red Line and the Green Line, and is clean and air conditioned. Pay with a rechargeable Nol card. Taxis and ride-hailing apps are affordable, and the abra boats across the creek cost only a few dirhams.

Dubai International Airport (DXB) is the world's busiest airport for international passengers and the hub of Emirates. The Red Line Metro connects the airport with the city centre. From Dubai, Emirates flies non-stop to Sydney in about 14 hours and to London in about 7 hours.

The currency is the UAE dirham (AED), which is pegged to the US dollar. Dress modestly in public places such as malls and souks, covering shoulders and knees.

The best time to visit Dubai is from November to March, when the weather is warm and sunny. From June to September temperatures often rise above 40 degrees Celsius, so outdoor sightseeing is uncomfortable.

# Dubai: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Visit the Burj Khalifa at sunset and watch the Dubai Fountain show, then explore Dubai Mall. Day 2: Explore old Dubai: the Al Fahidi neighbourhood, an abra ride across the creek, and the Gold and Spice Souks. In the afternoon go on a desert safari.

Day 3: Visit the Museum of the Future, relax on Jumeirah beach with a view of the Burj Al Arab, and walk around Dubai Marina in the evening.

Abu Dhabi, the capital of the UAE, is about 90 minutes away by road. There you can visit the Sheikh Zayed Grand Mosque, one of the largest mosques in the world, and the Louvre Abu Dhabi, a museum created in partnership with the Louvre in Paris. The mountain town of Hatta offers kayaking and hiking.

Because Emirates connects Dubai with so many cities, many travellers make Dubai a stopover on the way between London and Sydney or between Europe and Asia.